

(PERHAPS) THE MOST USEFUL PROBLEM IN THE HISTORY OF MODERN PHILOSOPHY

Small may not be the idea, after all—Where to find the powder room—Predict and perish—On school buses and intelligent textbooks

I am going to be blunt. Before *The Black Swan* (and associated papers) most of epistemology and decision theory was, to an actor in the real world, just sterile mind games and foreplay. Almost all the history of thought is about what we know, or think we know. *The Black Swan* is the *very first attempt* (that I know of) in the history of thought to provide a map of where we get hurt by what we don't know, to set systematic limits to the fragility of knowledge—and to provide exact locations where these maps no longer work.

To answer the most common “criticism” by economists and (now bankrupt) bankers I mentioned in Section III, I am not saying “S**t happens,” I am saying “S**t happens in the Fourth Quadrant,” which is as different as mistaking prudence and caution for paranoia.

Furthermore, to be more aggressive, while limits like those attributed to Gödel bear massive philosophical consequences, but we can't do much about them, I believe that the limits to empirical and statistical knowledge I have shown have sensible (if not vital) importance *and* we can do a lot with them in terms of solutions, by categorizing decisions based on the severity of the potential estimation error of the pair probability times consequence. For instance, we can use it to build a safer society—to robustify what lies in the Fourth Quadrant.

LIVING IN TWO DIMENSIONS

A vexing problem in the history of human thought is finding one's position on the boundary between skepticism and gullibility, or how to believe and how to *not* believe. And how to make decisions based on these beliefs, since beliefs without decisions are just sterile. So this is not an epistemological problem (i.e., focusing on what is true or false); it is one of decision, action, and commitment.